. . . all contributed to a society where the consumer marched one step ahead of the citizen. This new Indian wanted efficiency, good services and the ability to get rich fast (and yes, a nice smartphone!).

Culturally, globalization even spurred a return-to-roots faddishness, a nationalism born from anxieties about westernization. This unique historical moment where consumer culture and fascination with wealth sat alongside nationalism and a desire to see India as a First World economy created conditions for the Modi phenomenon. He promised wealth, uber-nationalism and access to quality public goods for those he liked to describe as the ‘neo-middle class’. This ‘neo-middle class’ was, in a sense, Modi’s answer to the Congress’s aam aadmi, and captured the vaulting aspirations of a rapidly changing India, from a taxi driver to a call centre operator and from a pizza delivery boy to a hair stylist in a small town. In this new India, within a fiercely competitive political environment, Sonia Gandhi seemed like a neta from another era; a younger, restless, aspirational India had no time for history lessons in Bharatiyata.

By early April, the whispers in the Congress corridors were getting louder: ‘If Rahul can’t deliver, if Sonia can’t revive us, can Priyanka save us?’